

Plenty of brawn and a giantkiller

AUSTRALIA AND ENGLAND ARE EXPECTED TO DOMINATE GROUP BUT **SCOTLAND COULD BE THE JOKER IN THE PACK.**

Dhruva Prasad

dhruva.prasad@thehindu.co.in

Other than reigniting cricket's oldest rivalry, Group B, comprising Australia, England, Namibia, Oman and Scotland, offers little in terms of throwing a spanner in the works as far as the make-up of the Super Eights is concerned. Australia and England, winners of the last two editions of the T20 World Cup, respectively, will expect to sail through the group stage with relative ease, riding on a bevy of all-round options.

Defending champion England has retained the core of its 2022 T20 World Cup-winning side, with as many as eight players who featured in the final against Pakistan finding a place in the squad for the upcoming event. Among the notable absentees are Ben Stokes, who opted out of the tournament in April, the retired Alex Hales, and Chris Woakes.

However, since lifting its second T20 title, England hasn't had a smooth run in the shortest format, having lost eight of its 12 matches, which include series defeats against Bangladesh and West Indies. The side's topsy-turvy returns closely mirror its captain Jos Buttler's mixed dividends in international cricket and the Indian Premier League (IPL) of late. However, England's top order will be buoyed by the fearless hitting ability of Phil Salt.

With Jonny Bairstow, Harry Brook, Liam Livingstone and Will Jacks to follow, England will hope to maintain the thrill-a-minute tempo that has come to define its cricket of late. Despite its recent failures, England is the third-fastest scoring team in T20Is in the last 12 months, going at 9.37 runs per over.

Tearaway speedster Jofra Archer's much-awaited return to international cricket from injury also bodes well

for England, which hasn't succeeded in identifying a pace spearhead in the run-up to the global showpiece. But given his spate of injuries (back and elbow) in recent years, Archer and England will have their 'fingers crossed'.

With Chris Jordan also being named in the squad, Archer will not be the only one returning from the international wilderness. Jordan last turned up for England last September, featuring in just the lone T20I in the four-match series against New Zealand at home, but his

